Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 2.7 Guided Notes: Forgetting and Other Memory Challenges

Unit 2: Cognition | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic2.7

Word Bank

Imagination Inflation	*Forgetting Curve (Ebbinghaus)*	*Encoding Failure*
Retrieval Failure	*Repression*	*Storage Decay*
Retroactive Interference	*Tip-of-the-Tongue Phenomenon*	*Reconsolidation*
Proactive Interference	*Misinformation Effect*	*Source Amnesia*

1. Why We Forget (Naturally)

Forgetting isn't always a bad thing; if you remembered every single detail of every single day, your brain would be overwhelmed with useless information. When we “forget” something, it usually falls into one of three categories:

- _____: The information never actually made it into your long-term memory in the first place. Think about a penny: you have seen thousands of them, but could you draw one perfectly from memory? Probably not, because you never put in the effortful processing required to encode the exact details.
- _____: Herman Ebbinghaus discovered that if you don't actively rehearse information, you lose a massive amount of it very quickly. His famous _____ shows that forgetting occurs rapidly right after initial learning, but then levels off over time.
- _____: The file is in the cabinet, but you can't find it. The most common example is the _____, where you know you know a word or name, and feel like you are inches away from recalling it, but lack the proper retrieval cues to pull it out.

Apply It: Which Type of Forgetting?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A student can't recall a single detail about the color of the socks he wore three days ago, because he was so distracted that he never actually paid attention to them in the first place.	
2	A woman crams a list of vocabulary words the night before her quiz and can recite them all perfectly the next morning, but two weeks later can barely remember any of them, since she never went back to review them again.	
3	A man is absolutely certain he knows the name of the actor from a movie he saw last week — it feels like it's right on the tip of his tongue — but he just can't manage to recall it in the moment, even though he's positive he'd recognize it instantly if someone said it out loud.	

2. When Memories Collide: Interference

Sometimes, memories act like competing radio signals, blocking each other out. This is known as interference, and it comes in two distinct directions:

- _____: When older information interferes with your ability to remember newer information. (Example: You change your computer password, but you keep accidentally typing in your old password).
- _____: When newer information interferes with your ability to remember older information. (Example: You learn Spanish this year, and suddenly you can't remember the French vocabulary you learned last year).

Apply It: Proactive or Retroactive?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	After years of parking in the same spot at her old job, a woman keeps walking toward that same spot out of habit during her first week at a brand-new job, even though her new assigned spot is in a completely different area.	
2	A musician learns a brand-new, complicated guitar solo for an upcoming concert, and afterward finds he can no longer remember how to play an old, simpler song he used to know by heart.	

3. Constructive Memory: Rewriting History

Every time you retrieve a memory, you don't just "play it back"—you actively reconstruct it. Because of this, memories can be easily manipulated without you ever realizing it.

- _____: Exposed by psychologist Elizabeth Loftus, this is the tendency for post-event information to distort a person's memory of the original event. If a police officer asks, "How fast were the cars going when they smashed into each other?" witnesses will remember the cars going much faster than if the officer asked, "How fast were the cars going when they bumped?"
- _____: When you accurately remember information but completely forget where, when, or how you learned it. (Example: You tell your friend a really funny joke, only for them to look at you blankly and say, "Yeah... I'm the one who told you that joke yesterday.")
- _____: Merely imagining a fake event repeatedly can make you feel more confident that it actually happened, creating a false memory.
- _____: The biological process where a retrieved memory is modified and altered before being put back into long-term storage. Every time you open the file, you write a little bit of fiction into it!

Apply It: Which Memory Distortion?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	After repeatedly imagining and describing a made-up childhood memory of getting lost in a shopping mall for a psychology experiment, a participant later becomes genuinely convinced the invented event actually happened to him.	

#	Scenario	Concept
2	Each time a woman recalls her wedding day, the memory itself is temporarily destabilized and can be subtly altered by her current mood or by new information before it's stored back in her long-term memory.	

4. Repression: The Psychodynamic Perspective

Proposed by Sigmund Freud, _____ is the idea that our minds unconsciously block painful, anxiety-producing, or traumatic memories from our conscious awareness to protect our ego. While modern memory researchers heavily debate how common repression actually is (most trauma survivors suffer from remembering the event too much, rather than forgetting it), it remains an important historical concept in psychodynamic theory.

📺 *Video Notes: "Essential Video Review: Remembering & Forgetting"*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. The video says memories are like spider webs rather than books in a library. What does that mean, what are retrieval cues, and how does priming work?

2. How do context, physical state, and mood each act as retrieval cues, according to the video? Include the video's examples.

3. What is the serial position effect? Use the video's grocery-list example to explain what the primacy and recency effects each do.

4. HWhat three ways does the video say we forget, what example does it give for each, and what happens to the rate of forgetting over time?

5. Describe Elizabeth Loftus's car-accident experiment and the Innocence Project statistic, then give two reasons the video says Bernice's identification of the banana thief could have been mistaken.

5. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Proactive vs. Retroactive Interference: The prefix tells you what is doing the BLOCKING. In _____, the PAST is blocking the present. In _____, the RECENT is blocking the past.

⚠️ Forgetting vs. Amnesia: Standard forgetting (like interference or decay) is a normal cognitive process. Amnesia (Topic 2.5) is typically the result of brain damage, physical trauma, or neurological disease.

6. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. Despite seeing thousands of pennies throughout his life, a man realizes he cannot accurately draw one from memory, including the exact placement of the words and imagery. This is because he never put in the effortful processing needed to encode those specific details in the first place. This type of forgetting is called:

- **A.** Encoding Failure
- **B.** Retrieval Failure
- **C.** Storage Decay
- **D.** Repression

2. A researcher famous for studying memory found that people lose a massive amount of newly learned information very quickly right after learning it, unless they actively rehearse it, but the rate of forgetting then levels off significantly over time. This famous finding is best known as the:

- **A.** Forgetting Curve (Ebbinghaus)
- **B.** Serial Position Effect
- **C.** Misinformation Effect
- **D.** Testing Effect

3. After recently changing his computer password, a man keeps accidentally typing his old, familiar password out of habit, even though he consciously knows it no longer works. This is best explained by:

- **A.** Source Amnesia
- **B.** Retroactive Interference
- **C.** Reconsolidation
- **D.** Proactive Interference

4. A police officer asks a witness, "How fast were the cars going when they smashed into each other?" instead of using a more neutral word like "bumped." As a result, the witness later recalls the crash as being far more severe and the cars going much faster than they actually were. This phenomenon, exposed by psychologist Elizabeth Loftus, is called:

- **A.** Source Amnesia
- **B.** Imagination Inflation
- **C.** Repression
- **D.** The Misinformation Effect

5. A man excitedly tells his friend a hilarious joke, only for his friend to point out that he was actually the one who told that exact same joke to the man just the day before. The man accurately remembered the joke's content but had completely forgotten where or from whom he originally learned it. This is called:

- **A.** The Misinformation Effect
- **B.** Retroactive Interference
- **C.** Source Amnesia
- **D.** Reconsolidation

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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